or evade criticism or opposition'.[172] Throughout this time, however, the Indian government remained a vocal critic of Curzon's Persian policy. For, when it came to the issue of Bolshevism, Delhi was adamant that the new regime in Russia only constituted a real threat to British interests if the South Asian people and their governments were mishandled so much as to push them towards Moscow.[173] In contrast to Curzon and Cox, Chelmsford and Hamilton Grant were apt to downplay the threat of Bolshevism to Afghanistan. Indeed, the Indian government appeared to recognise that while there may have been a new government in Russia, Afghanistan was using old tactics in trying to play its neighbours off against each other: using fear of Bolshevism to try to gain concession from the Indian government. In these respects, when it came to handling the three-way dynamic between India, Afghanistan and Bolshevik Russia, the Indian government was more astute than its colleagues in London gave credit for.

Delhi also appeared attuned to the changes that had occurred in southern Asia since the First World War, so that imperial dominance was no longer simply an accepted fact and that the threat of force was increasingly coming to lose its potency in the face of potential mass Asian nationalist and pan-Islamist unrest. It understood, for example, that 'a genuine nationalistic spirit was alive in Iran, despite its seeming confusion, and…felt that this force should be recognised and conciliated'.[174] British policy was going to have to change. Indeed, when Montagu argued that the viceroy was going against 40 years of tradition in his handling of the Afghan peace process Chelmsford responded: '"It has been the cardinal policy of His Majesty's Government for the past forty years...." and the whole world has blown sky high in the last four!'[175] The Indian government also realised that while Britain may have just 'issued triumphantly from a struggle with the greatest military power the world has ever seen', economically and militarily it had been weakened by the experience.[176] A large part of its southern Asian policy in 1918–1919 was, therefore, conditioned not only by its views on the potency of nationalism and pan-Islamism but by the basic premise of incurring the least amount of strain on India's resources, particularly when the country itself was undergoing so much domestic unrest. After all, alliances based on trust and friendship ultimately cost much less than those based on financial and military inducements. In this respect, then, the agreements of 1919 reflect the optimism of Curzon against the realism of